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QATAR CROWNED THE KING OF ASIA, AGAIN

The 2023 Asian Cup became Qatar's **redemption ground**, as it exorcised its World Cup demons through a relentless title defence.

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Football, bloody hell.' Sir Alex Ferguson's famous aphorism has been iterated so much that it feels too trite to recall. But it still emerges as a phoenix, absolving the sport of any figment of predictability.

At the Asian Cup 2023, the biggest tournament in Asia after the World Cup, that became the norm rather than an aberration.

As compared to the 2019 edition, the only other 24-team Asian Cup before this, it had more goals, double the number of penalty shootouts, and thrice the number of decisive stoppage time goals in knockouts.

This tournament had everything — a leaf out of the World Cup's book of grandeur, the congregation of the Arab world to support their teams, the seduction of politics into the beautiful game, and also a fair share of controversies with the refereeing.

While Jurgen Klinsmann complained about the

« I would like to thank all Qataris. Congratulations to the coach and the fans. I can't really express what we feel but the coach worked really hard for us — Akram Afif of Qatar »



referee giving 'too many yellow cards' to his players (South Korea), Iraq's star goalscorer Aymen Hussein was sent off for time-wasting after his second yellow card — a decision that saw Jordan ultimately win that game 3-2.

The Asian Cup came a full circle on February 10, with Qatar winning consecutive titles — the first in the tournament since Japan in 2004 — at the same venue where it began its campaign, the Lusail Stadium.

Akram Afif, the architect of its title run four years ago — with the maximum number of assists (10) — scored a hat-trick of penalties to